10

IT WAS A FANTASY COME TRUE. On a Monday morning in the first week of June in 1937, I drove my convertible through the gates of the Warner Brothers lot in Burbank, ready for work, and with a hole in my stomach as deep as an oil well. I asked myself, what am I doing here? Once again, I felt like the new kid in school.

Here I was, a twenty-six-year-old radio announcer from Iowa suddenly rubbing shoulders with stars like Errol Flynn, Pat O'Brien, and Olivia de Havilland. They were professional actors. It had been five years since I had done any acting, and that was in a college play. I wasn't quite an Iowa hayseed. But I'd never been east of Chicago, north of Minneapolis, south of the Ozarks.

When I was introduced to Edward Everett Horton, he said kindly: "Glad to meet you, Reagan. We need some new faces around here. Hope you stick around."

So did I.

I'd learned there was a clause in my contract that allowed Warner Brothers to fire me after six months if they were unhappy with me. So much for the publicity department's announcement Warners had signed me to a "long-term contract."

In a studio screening room my first day, I was shown the test that had led Warners to offer me a contract and I wanted to bury myself under my seat. I was terrible. I hated it. After that I figured I'd be on a train bound for Des Moines in time for Christmas.

I was in the same boat as all the contract players. The studio liked to keep you a little off balance and uncertain how long you'd stay. George Ward tried to console me with